

THE WHITE HOUSE

WASHINGTON

MEMORANDUM OF CONVERSATION

SUBJECT: Pull-Aside Meeting with President Slobodan
Milosevic of Serbia (U)

PARTICIPANTS: U.S.
The President
Warren Christopher, Secretary of State
Anthony Lake, Assistant to the President
for National Security Affairs
Richard Holbrooke, Assistant Secretary of
State for European and Canadian Affairs
Alexander Vershbow, Senior Director for
European Affairs, NSC Staff (Notetaker)

Serbia
Slobodan Milosevic, President of Serbia
Momir Bulatovic, President of Montenegro
Milan Milutinovic, Minister of Foreign
Affairs of the Federal Republic of
Yugoslavia
Goran Milinovic, Chief of Cabinet to
President Milosevic
Other Advisors

DATE, TIME December 14, 1995, 10:05-10:15 a.m.
AND PLACE: U.S. Ambassador's Residence, Paris, France

The President: I just wanted to say that I know that this agreement would not have been possible without you. Whatever our differences in the past, you made Dayton possible. Now it is important to make it work. I want to personally ask that you work with Admiral Smith. He's a good man and committed to his mission. If you cooperate, I think we can make it happen. We are depending on you to keep the radicals among the Bosnian Serbs from derailing the agreement. On Sarajevo, I know you had a long discussion with President Izetbegovic. He needs to make the Serbs who stay in the Federation -- and we hope that many of them will stay -- believe that they will be treated fairly and have their voices heard. ~~(c)~~

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President Milosevic: The only dangerous spot is Sarajevo. This is not because of a direct material threat, but because of the psychology of the situation. If there is an understanding on an implementation plan -- a transition period that makes the Serbs feel that they have a real choice -- then things will calm down. I explained this to Admiral Smith when I met him together with Ambassador Harriman. We have time to work this out. ~~(C)~~

The keys to solving all problems are in the Dayton agreement. The force commander is authorized to extend the transition period if, in his personal judgment, an extension is needed. So he can use the possibility he has under the agreement. Please encourage Izetbegovic to understand this now. The winter is not adequate for the transition period; it must be extended in order to calm the situation. ~~(C)~~

You know, I asked Izetbegovic if he wants to keep the Serbs in Sarajevo or not. You must understand that he would like them to go and stay at the same time -- he wants enough Serbs to stay as are needed to maintain his international image. That is the reality. Sarajevo was a big wound for Europe at the beginning of this century; it led to the start of World War I. It would be better not to prolong the existence of this wound. People must have a choice. Under the Dayton agreement, people are free to choose their place of residence. This is more important than the statistics of how many Serbs and how many Muslims there are in Sarajevo. Let's ensure freedom of movement and individual freedom and then let people decide. We need a transition period to move to a new situation. There will need to be a new cultural center in the eastern part of the Republika Srpska -- for a university, academy of sciences, museums, national theater -- but this will be in the same neighborhood as Sarajevo, that is, in Pale and Lukavica. So this will be manageable if there is an understanding on implementation. ~~(C)~~

Secretary Christopher: I want to thank President Milosevic for his cooperation with the recent Congressional delegations. ~~(C)~~

President Milosevic: Some of them said they would like you to see so many Congressmen in such a short time, Mr. President! ~~(C)~~

Secretary Christopher: You and I had some difficult sessions in Dayton, but you have done what you said you would. ~~(C)~~

President Milosevic: Without your help, Mr. Christopher, we would not have achieved the result. You were the key at critical moments. ~~(C)~~

The President: I understand you were a big hit at the shopping mall. (U)

Secretary Christopher: And at the Officer's Club. (U)

President Milosevic: We had a good time there. (U)

The President: Although things have been calm since the ceasefire, the press is always looking for something bad to report. ~~(C)~~

President Milosevic: For the press, only bad news is good news. Mr. President, may I ask you to think of full normalization of relations with Federal Yugoslavia. We have been allies throughout our history. Few countries have had such close relations for so long with the United States. We stood shoulder to shoulder in two world wars. The spoiling of our relations was over a third issue and the result of a distorted picture on the part of your public opinion. We need full normalization -- we are the central factor in the Balkans. ~~(C)~~

The President: We've established that. (U)

President Milosevic: I don't see any reason not to have full normalization. (U)

Secretary Christopher: You've taken a big step today. ~~(C)~~

Richard Holbrooke: Mr. President, we can't keep President Chirac waiting. (U)

The President: Dick has done well so far, hasn't he? (U)

President Milosevic: He's a lucky man. Now the rest of you have to implement his agreement. (U)

-- End of Conversation --